FORM is a design theory podcast that uses minimalism to ask the questions most designers think but never say out loud.

From the Bauhaus workshops to Dieter Rams' ten principles of good design, from Apple's "less is more" idea to the global spread of Nordic graphic style, the idea of "less" has shaped the world. And it also makes us ask: who was this world designed for? Today, we use minimalism in many ways: to sell products, explain interface design, praise architecture, clean up our rooms, or even as a way of living.

FORM is a design theory podcast that uses minimalism to ask questions that many designers think about but rarely say out loud. The podcast is hosted by Paola Antonelli and John Maeda. In each episode, they start from minimalism and talk about problems. It comes from different industries or some interdisciplinary fields. Understand minimalism design and how it shaped design theory from a richer perspective. FORM is a podcast about thinking "why design this way." It helps us see the ideas behind each design decision, and explore some important questions: What does "form follows function" really mean? When does an aesthetic judgment slowly become a moral judgment? Can design ever be truly neutral, or does every visual choice carry some kind of idea or belief? The most important question minimalism asks is not "how little can we use?" but "less for whom?" was never how little can we use?

Form

- Circles
- Water Pipe
- Bubble Blower

Designer, technologist, and author of The Laws of Simplicity, has built his career at the intersection of reduction and meaning — across software, products, and ideas. Former President of RISD, equally fluent in Silicon Valley and the studio.

Senior Curator of Architecture & Design at MoMA, has spent decades reframing design as a fundamental human practice — not decoration. Her TED talks and exhibitions have brought serious design thinking to audiences worldwide.

In this episode, we invited both our host, design theorist John Maeda, and Japanese graphic designer Kenya Hara to share their thinking about simplicity.

Simplicity is often understood as reducing things, but John Maeda thinks it is more complicated than that. He talks about a common problem in design: “On the one hand, you want a product or service to be easy to use; on the other hand you want it to do everything that a person might want it to do.” For Maeda, simplicity is not only about function, but also about feeling. A good design should not only work well, but also make people feel something, even something small. So simplicity is not empty.

When it comes to simplicity feeling, Kenya Hara gives another way to think about it through MUJI which is a representative lifestyle and design philosophy on worldwide. He writes, “MUJI’s perspective is unique; in the MUJI concept, design intervenes in the making of things.” This is different from a world that is driven by money and consumption. MUJI shows another kind of aesthetic. Hara thinks Japanese design focuses on simplicity, not as something missing, but as a kind of quiet beauty.

Together, these ideas show that simplicity is not just about how things look. They also explore how minimalism has shaped design theory. What does “form follows function” really mean?

Episode 1: Simplicity as Thinking

Guest:
Hara Kenya

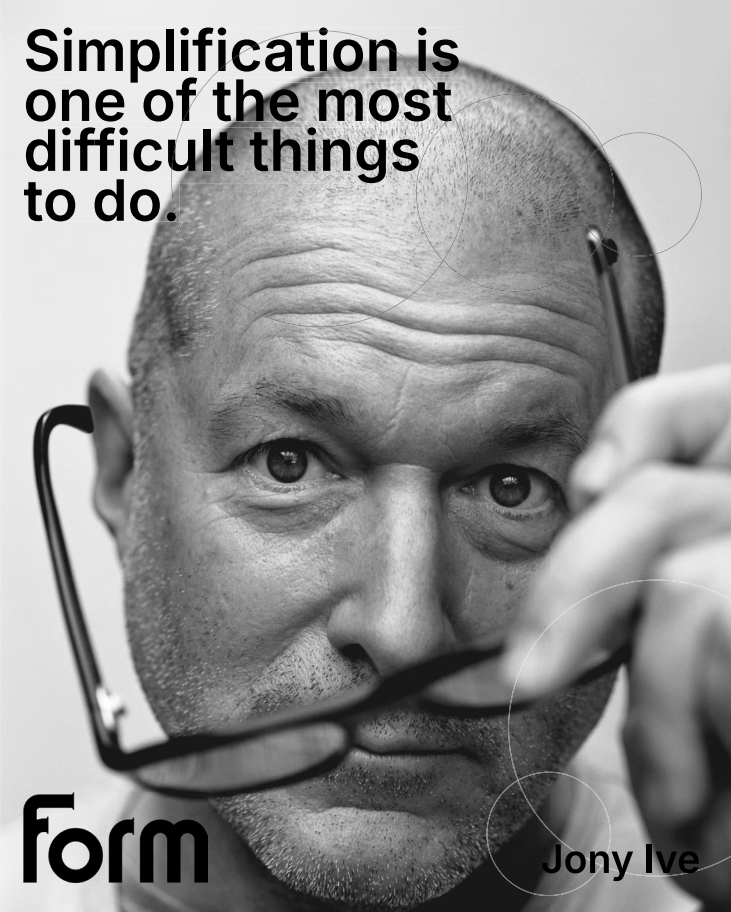
In this episode, we invite British-American designer Jony Ive to talk about how minimalist design can empower people and give them inspiration.

For Jony Ive, a common misunderstanding is that simplicity means just removing things. When this happens, the result is often a product that looks clean, but feels empty or without life. Many minimalist or modernist designs fall into this trap.

Instead, Ive believes the goal of design is to bring order to chaos. It is about clearly expressing what something is, what it is for, and how it fits into people's lives. In his view, good design is not about reducing meaning, but about making meaning clearer. In the technology world, especially in Silicon Valley, humor and joy are often missing. Products are usually complex, and joy is sometimes seen as unimportant or even childish. But Ive believes this is a mistake. He thinks the mindset of the creator always shows in the work. If the designer feels stressed or anxious, the product will also feel like that. For him, simplicity is not only a visual result, but also a way of thinking and working. It comes from care, focus, and emotional awareness in the design process. As he often suggests, design is not just about how things look, but about how they make people feel and behave.

Through this podcast, we explore how Jony Ive and Apple approach design: a process that moves from complexity, through reduction, and finally toward clarity and emotional connection.

Episode 2: Simplicity as Empowerment



Episode3: Simplicity in Fashion

Guests:
Jil Sander

Phoebe Philo

In this episode, we bring in two important figures from fashion: Jil Sander and Phoebe Philo. Both of them are well known in the fashion world, and their work is often connected with minimalism.
Jil Sander is often called the “Queen of Less.” She believes that simplicity is not weak, but powerful. Her design focuses on clean shapes, careful details, and high-quality materials. Instead of adding more decoration, she tries to remove what is unnecessary. As she once said, “I like to concentrate on what is essential.” This shows that for her, minimalism is about focus and control.
Phoebe Philo has a different but related approach. During her time at Chloé, Philo brought “easy-to-wear, feelgood designs”. She designs for real life, especially for women. Her idea of simplicity is not only about clean visuals, but also about how clothes make people feel. In an interview, she said, “I think about women, and what they want to wear.”

Both designers show that minimalism in fashion is not only about reducing things. It is about what to keep, what to remove, and what really matters. Their work also shows that simplicity can have different expressions: it can be strict and controlled, or soft and personal.

FORM & PODCAST
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Yue Zhou